LegiScan API Crash Course

Thank You! Your survey response has been submitted.

Query Limits

- Public API keys have 30,000 queries to spend per month, resetting on the first of each month
- Pull API subscriptions for expanded query limits and Push API subscriptions for full enterprise replication
- Timing guidelines for each operation on Page 7 of the LegiScan API Manual should be followed
- Recommend local caching of JSON response to minimize spend on replayability
- Always check the "`status`" code in JSON responses for "`OK`" or "`ERROR`" and act appropriately

Datasets

- Created weekly on Sunday morning at 5am Eastern
- All individual `getBill`, `getRollCall` and `getPerson` JSON payloads in a single ZIP file for each legislative session
- Approximately 1000 API queries for 3,500,000+ records for all 2010 - 2026 data
- ZIP archive files are Base64 encoded in their JSON transport
- Use `dataset_hash` to prevent duplicative downloads, failure to do so will result in suspended access

Texts & Documents

- Bill documents are available via `getBillText`, `getAmendment` and `getSupplement` hooks
- Necessary `doc_id`, `amendment_id`, `supplement_id` identifiers are availble in `getBill` payloads
- Document blobs are Base64 encoded in their JSON transport
- There is no need to download the same document blob more than once
- One-time snapshot of complete 350GB data for all 2010 - 2026 sessions available as separate paid service

Hashes

- 32-character hash values are available to detect data changes and optimize query spend
- `change_hash + bill_id` for bill data; available in `getBill`, `getMasterList`, `getSearch`, `getMasterListRaw`, `getSearchRaw`
- `dataset_hash + session_id` for dataset archives; available in `getDatasetList`, `getDataset`
- Store and compare hash values, if hash is the same the data is the same so use local cache and avoid query spend
- Use the hashes. No. Really. Use them.

Work Loop

- Typical loop driven by checking `getMasterListRaw` or `getSearchRaw` periodically
- Use `change_hash` in the results to determine when to spend queries updating individual data
- Repeat `getMasterListRaw` or `getSearchRaw` daily/weekly or as needed within query spend
- Open source turnkey LegiScan API Client available to processes Pull, Push and Bulk data into a defined SQL schema

Housekeeping

- Scraping the legiscan.com front end site is prohibited and will result in suspended access
- Creating multiple Public API service keys is prohibited and will result in suspended access
- All data is licensed under Creative Commons Attribution 4.0; do as you like but you must give LegiScan attribution
- Play nice! Respect the free public service!